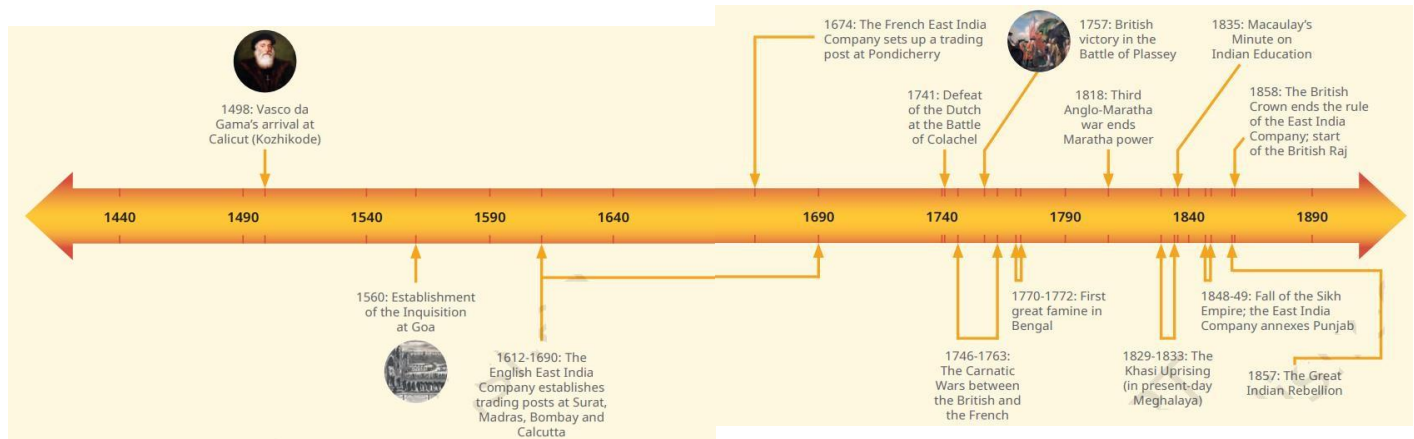


Chapter – 4: The Colonial Era in India

Nearly two centuries ago the early Britons in Bengal and the sister Presidencies regarded the land and the people as fair game for plunder. ... Under the later Britons, as administrators ... the plunder is proceeding far more outrageously today than at any preceding period. ... Modern England has been made great by Indian wealth, ... wealth always taken by the might and skill of the stronger. — William Digby (1901)



- Previous chapter – saw – Marathas – weaken – Mughal empire – succumbed themselves – British forces – 19th cent.
- Military campaigns – only 1 factor – India – jewel in the Crown – British empire – empire's largest colony

The Age of Colonialism

- Before getting there – step back – time – consider – colonialism
- Usual definition – practice – 1 country – take control – another region – establish settlements – impose – political, economic, cultural sys.
- This – not recent – colonialism – traced – great empires – 1st millennium BCE – 1st millennium CE – spread – Christianity, Islam – also involved – colonization – territories – converted – new faiths
- BUT – age of colonialism – refers – Europe's expansion – 15th cent. onward – few cent. – extended – large parts – world
- Discover – higher grades – European powers – Spain, Portugal, Britain, France, Netherlands – establish colonies – Africa, Asia, Americas, Australia, Pacific Islands
- Often – conquests – achieved – military campaigns – massacre, **enslavement** – native populations
- Political competition – European powers – race – territorial expansion – global influence
- Territorial expansion – obvious economic adv. – access – new natural resources – new markets – new routes – often plunder
- Converging indigenous populations – Christianity – powerful motivation
- Lesser one – significant – scientific inquiry – desire – explore – unknown lands – accumulate knowledge – planet's geography – natural history
- Colonisers – claimed – civilising mission – bringing progress – colonized people – often **demonized** – savage, primitive, barbaric – reality – very diff. – loss – independence – exploitation – resources – destruction – traditional ways – imposition – foreign cultural values
- True – colonial age – brought world – together – rapid growth – economics, tech. – BUT – benefits – mostly – colonisers – many historic studies – documented – hardships – colonized people – endure
- Many colonized regions – resistance – against colonisers

- Phenomenon – colonialism – declined – mid-20th cent. – after – World War II – many factors – contribute – rapid decolonization – most colonized countries – independent
- This chapter – focus – special case – India

Europeans in India

- India – trade – Greeks, Romans – over 2 millennia ago
- Indian goods – spices, cotton, ivory, gems, sandalwood, teakwood, wootz steel – high demand – Mediterranean world
- Until 16th cent. – European powers – start sailing – Indian subcontinent – India – economic, cultural powerhouse
- Historical estimates – India's contribution – 1/4th world **GDP** – this period – one of 2 largest economies – 2nd – China
- Remarkable – 16th cent. onward – European travelers – India – describe her – flourishing – noted – manufacturing capabilities, diverse agricultural output, extensive trade network
- This prosperity – India – attractive target – European colonial ambitions

The Portuguese: commerce and atrocities

- Portuguese explorer, navigator – Vasco da Gama – arrival – Kappad – May 1498 – paved way – beginning – European colonization – India
- Vasco da Gama – well received – aggressive ways – failed relations – local rulers
- 2nd voyage – 4 yrs. later – seized, tortured, killed – Indian merchants – bombarded Calicut
- Portuguese – captured strategic ports – incl. Goa – 1510 – capital – their colony – also – trading ports – Malabar, Coromandel coasts
- Portugues – implemented – *cartaz* sys. – require – all ships – Arabian sea – purchase – Portuguese permits – navigation
- Ships – without permits – seized
- Naval dominance – allowed – monopolize – spice trade – India, Europe – cent.
- Along commercial exploitation – Portuguese presence – Western India – characterized – religious persecution
- Goa – they established – **Inquisition** – 1560 – severely persecuted – Hindus, Muslims, Jews, Christian converts – suspected – practicing – original faiths
- Such persecution – accompanied by – forced conversions – destruction – many Hindu temples – other forms – abuse – native population

The Dutch: commerce and competition

- Dutch – arrived India – early 17th cent. – unlike Portuguese – focus – commercial dominance – specially spice trade
- Established – Dutch East India Company – trading posts – various parts – India – west coast – Surat, Baruch, Cochin – east coast – Nagapattinam, Masulipatnam
- Most significant presence – Malabar region – Kerala – displaced Portuguese – several trading centres
- Dutch presence – India – limited – declined significantly – defeat – Battle of Colachel – 1741 – forces – Travancore – King Marthanda Varma – defeat Dutch – land, sea
- This battle – rare ex. – Asian power – repel – European colonial force

The French: colonial ambitions

- French – entered India – later – 1st trading post – Surat – 1668 – Pondicherry – 1674

- There – established – East India Company – developed plans – French empire – India
- Dupleix – Governor-General – French India – 1742-1754 – several colonial strategies – later – adopted by British
- Also trained – Indian soldiers – European military tech. – create – disciplined infantry soldiers – *sepoys*
- Dupleix – developed strategy – indirect rule – puppet Indian rulers – installed – intervention – local successions disputes
- French colonial ambitions – India – checked – Carnatic wars (1746-1763) – series – conflicts – Britain, France
- Initial success – Dupleix – captured Madras – 1746 – French – lost to British – colony – reduced – Pondicherry, few smaller enclaves
- Like Dutch – unlike Portuguese – French powers – not much intervention – India – social, religious life
- Rare exception – destruction – 1748 – Pondicherry – Vedapurishwaran temple – ordered by – Dupleix – request of – Jesuit priests, Dupleix own wife – view – asserting dominance – Christianity
- Generally – French – content – modest amt. – trade – India

Enter the British

- Britain – dominated Indian subcontinent – 2 cent.
- Many books – dissected methods – British rules – BUT – this chapter – not complete story – focus – main aspects – their colonial presence – India

From traders and rulers

- British conquest – India – history – most remarkable ex. – trading company – transform – imperial power
- Unlike other conquests – British takeover – gradual, calculated – disguised – commercial enterprise
- English East India Company – estd. – trading company – royal charter – Queen Elizabeth I – special powers – raise – private army
- Agents – initially – pretense – mere traders – allowed them – 17th cent. – establish footholds – India's coast – minimal resistance – Surat, Madras, Bombay, Calcutta
- Local rulers – no problem – welcomed – foreign trade
- Modest beginnings – concealed – long-term ambitions
- **The strategy of divide and rule**
 - Maintaining appearance – traders – Company agents – political rel. – local rulers – offering military support – inserting themselves – Indian political conflicts – power brokers
 - Also play – rivalries – regional rulers – succession disputes – ruling houses – benefit – these conflicts
 - British – equally skilled – exploiting – divisions – Indian society – identified, encouraged – tensions – religious communities
- Battle of Plassey – 1757 – exemplify – this approach
- Tensions arose – Siraj-ud-Daulah (Nawab, Bengal) – East India Company officials – Robert Clive – identified – disgruntled elements – Nawab's court
- Clive – conspiracy – Mir Jafar – military commander – promise him – install – new Nawab – for betrayal
- Battle – Palashi (Plassey – British called it) – 150 km North – Kolkata
- French forces – assisted Nawab – BUT – Mir Jafar's forces – majority – Nawab's army – did not fight – ensure – British victory

- Even today – Mir Jafar – synonym – traitor
- East India Company – position themselves – kingmaker – estd. control – very large territories
- 19th cent. – step further – intro. – infamous – **Doctrine of Lapse** – a/c. – any princely state – annexed – if ruler died – no natural male heir
- This policy – disregard – Hindu tradition – adoption – legitimate means – succession – royal houses
- Doctrine of Lapse – annexation – numerous states – contribute – expansion – territorial control – British
- Created – much resentment – sections – Indian society – contribute – 1857 rebellion
- Another stratagem – **subsidiary alliance** – install – British Resident – courts – Indian rulers – protect them – internal, external threats – exchange – maintain – British troops – own expense – foreign rel. – only through British
- Appear – preserve sovereignty – princely states – BUT – sys. – transfer real power – British – burden Indian rulers – cost – own subjugation
- Ruler – Hyderabad – 1st – enter – such alliance – 1798 – others – soon follow
- So-called alliances – allowed British – control – vast territories – without – admin. cost – direct rule – create – empire on the cheap
- Any state – enter sys. – exiting – impossible – attempts – break free – face – British military response

From paradise to Hell?

Devastating famines

- Few yrs. later – victory – Plassey – East India Company – secured right – collect revenue – Bengal, Bihar, Odisha – India's richest regions
- Clive – describes Bengal – **paradise** of earth
- Company agents – extract – max. revenue – invest – min. – governance, development – devastating consequences – population
- 1770-1772 – 2 yrs. – crop failure – harsh revenue collection – imposed by – Company – Bengal – req. farmers – pay high rate – taxes – on produce – regardless – harvest conditions – catastrophic famine – killed – 1/3rd population – 10 million
- Company – maintain – harsh revenue targets – increasing land tax – in famine
- Such cruelty – denounced later – Indian personalities – even – British officials – public intellectuals
- Cent. later – W. W. Hunter – wrote –
 - Country – every yr. – getting worse – English govt. – demand – increased tax
 - All through – 1770 – summer – people died
 - Farmers – sold cattle – implements – agriculture – seed-grains – sons, daughters – no buyer – available – ate – leaves, grass
 - Day, night – torrent – famished, disease-stricken – wretches – poured – great cities
- Such tragic famines – recur – British rule – India
- Great famine – 1876-1878 – 8 million Indians – died – Deccan plateau
- Disregarding – severity – crisis – some Indian traders – hold stocks – hope – price rise – artificial scarcity – British admin. – continue – export grains – Britain – 1 million tonnes / yr. – rice – 3 yrs. – famine
- Apart from factors – above – British economic policy – free market – left prices – commodities – free – fluctuate – contribute – severity – famines
- Lord Lytton – Viceroy – India – famine – 1876-1878 – issue order – no interference – govt.'s part – reducing price – food
- Same time – 1876 – Lytton – organise – extravagant durbar – Delhi – week-long feast – 68000 officials, satraps, maharajas

- Precise no. – severe famines – entire British rule – vary – dozen to 20
- A/c – several famine commissions – other reports – estimated – total no. – human victims – 50-100 million – close to – deaths – World War II
- British admin. – open – famine relief camps – some cities – BUT – no. – very few – also – inadequate supplies
- Some officials – argue – famine relief – deliberately low – famine commission – 1878-80 – stated –
 - Doctrine – famine time – poor – entitled – demand relief – lead to – doctrine – entitled – such relief – all times
- Note – famines – India – throughout history – draughts, floods, military campaigns – BUT – never – such scale
- Colonial era – India – especially – rural India – sank – deep poverty – no recovery

The drain of India's wealth

- Saw earlier – economic exploitation – India – foundation – British colonial policy
- 1895 – US historian, political scientist – Brooks Adams –
 - After Plassey – very soon – Bengal plunder – arrive – London – effect – appear – instantaneous
 - All authorities – agree – industrial revolution – began – 1760 – no investment – yielded – such profits – Indian plunder
- Other words – Industrial revolution – Britain – req. investment – possible – partly – stolen wealth – India – this phrase – US historian – Will Durant
- Taking cue – scholars – Adams, Digby – Dadabhai Naoroji – respected political fig. – authored – 1901 – *Poverty and Un-British Rule in India* – compiled – British reports – wealth – drained out – India
- Same time – Romesh Chunder Dutt – historian – similar exercise – *Economic History of India*
- All studies – colonisers – extracted – many billion pounds – India
- More recent estimate – Utsa Patnaik – period – 1765-1938 – 45 trillion US Dollars – today's values – 13x Britain's GDP – 2023
- This money – extracted – taxes – BUT also – charging Indians – colonial expenditure – building railways, telegraph network, wars
- This wealth – invested in India – this country – very diff. – after independence

Changing Landscapes

- Expanding colonial rule – impacted – every aspect – Indian life – rulers – convinced – India – reshaped – 'superior' conceptions

Decline of India's indigenous industries

- Before 18th cent. – India – renowned – manufacturing capabilities – textiles – cotton, silk, wool, jute, hemp, coir
- Indian cotton textiles – ultra-thin muslins – richly **embossed** fabrics – high demands – many parts – world
- British policy – heavy duties – Indian textiles – imported – Britain – force India – accept British goods – minimal tariffs
- Britain – now control – most sea trade, exchange rates – Indian traders – difficult to export
- Result – ruin – Indian textile industry
- 19th cent. – textile exports – fell – Britain's import – grew further
- Communities – skilled artisans – practice craft – generations – poverty – forced – return to agriculture – overtaxed land

- William Bentinck – Governor-General – obs. – 1834 – bones – cotton weavers – bleaching – planes – India
- Similar scenarios – India's manufacture – iron, steel, paper, other goods
- India's share – world GDP – declined rapidly – 5% - Independence
- 2 cent. – richest land – poorest

Dismantling traditional governance structures

- Before colonization – India – well-organized sys. – local self-governance
- Village councils – community affairs – resolve disputes – organise – public works – irrigation, roads
- Regional kingdoms – maintain – complex structures – evolved – over cent. – address – local needs, conditions
- Charles Metcalfe – acting Governor-General – 1830s – described – sys., efficiency – imp. statement –
 - Village comm. – little republics – have everything – they want
 - Dynasty after dynasty – tumble down – village comm. – remain same
 - This union – village comm. – forming – separate little state – contribute more – preserve – people of India
- British – dismantle – indigenous governance sys. – replace them – centralized bureaucracy – collect tax – maintain order – not public welfare
- This transformation – destroy – cent. old sys. – decision-making
- Intro. – British codes – law – disregard – laws, practice – governed India – generations
- Presented – modernization – imposition – foreign sys. – unsuited – India – alienated – ordinary Indians – judicial sys. – courts – expensive, time-consuming, conducted – foreign lang.

Transforming Indian education: creating brown Englishmen

- Education – powerful tool – creation – class – Indians – serve – British interests
- Earlier cent. – India – diverse education – *pathshalas, madrasas, viharas* – many forms – apprenticeship learning
- These institutions – practical knowledge – BUT also – cultural values, traditions
- Even – early 19th cent. – British reports – 100s of 1000s of village schools – across India – ex. – 100,000-150,000 – Bengal, Bihar – 1830 – young natives – taught – reading, writing, arithmetic – economic sys. – simple, effectual
- Sharp turning point – India's education history – marked by – notorious – 1853 **Minute on Indian Education** – British historian, politician – Thomas B. Macaulay
- He admit – no knowledge – Sanskrit, Arabic – expressed conviction – European knowledge – vastly superior –
 - Never found – among **Orientalists** – deny – single shelf – European library – more worth – whole native literature – India, Arabia
 - Indians – need education – British – objective – create class – Indian – blood, color – BUT – English – taste, opinions, morals, intellect
- Few British Orientalists – argue – Indian students – left – study – own lang.
- Macaulay's policy – upper hand – India's traditional schools – disappeared – English – lang. – prestige – associated – colonial masters – result – lasting divisions – Indian society – b/w – English-educated class and masses
- New education sys. – multiple colonial objectives
- Created pool – Indian clerks, minor officials – staff – lower ranks – colonial admin. – fraction of cost – British personnel

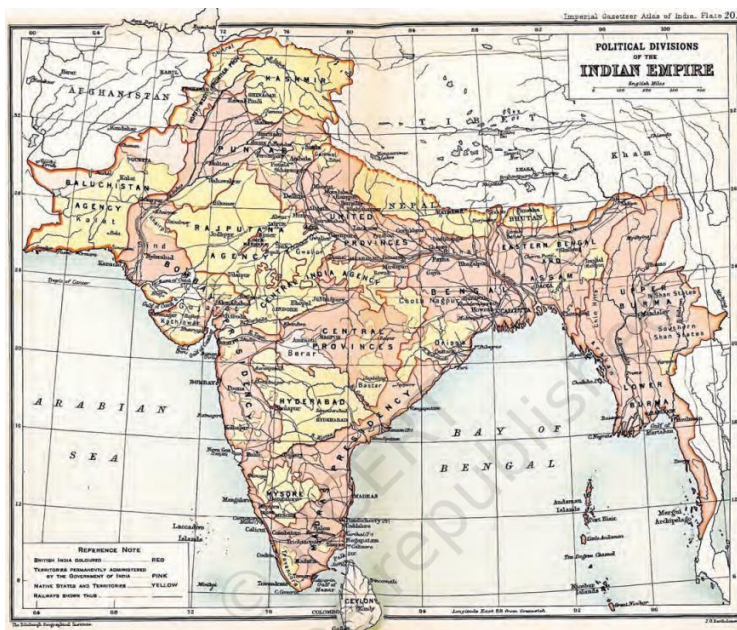
- Also sidelined – traditional forces – knowledge, authority – create generations – Indians – disconnected – own cultural heritage

Reshaping economic structures to serve imperial needs

- British – transformed India's economy – self-sufficient agriculture sys. – craft, production – TO – supplier – raw materials – British industry – market – forced – buy British goods
- Without going into tech. details – economic transformation – take ex. – construction – India's vast railway network – often termed – colonial blessing
- Railways – bring people together – integrated India's internal market – BUT – designed – move raw materials – interior to ports – export – distribute – British goods – throughout India
- Railway routes – ignored trade patterns – serve – colonial interests
- Another purpose – quick movement – armies – from cantonments – if fight happens – distant rebellion, war
- Construction – India's railway – no gift – colonial rulers
- Most of it – paid by – Indian tax revenue – Indian funded infrastructure – served British interests – instead – focusing on people's needs
- Same issue – telegraph network
- Admin. costs – colonialism – borne by – Indian subjects
- Colonial admin. apparatus – military installations – lavish lifestyles – British officials – India – financed by Indian taxes

Early Resistance Movements: Challenging Colonial Authority

- India – enormous src. – wealth, natural, human resources – British – nicknamed – jewel in the crown of British empire
- They asserted – India – forever part – British empire – sun never sets
- Almost beginning – British conquest – India – resistance movements – try, repel – self-imposed guest
- Briefly survey – such movements – BUT – before that – good look – British Indian empire
- Red, pink territories – direct control – British admin. – yellow ones – princely states – discussed earlier – black lines – railway lines



The Sannyasi-Fakir rebellion

- Earliest organized resistance – the Sannyasi rebellion – began – Bengal – terrible famine – 1770
- Grps. – sannyasis (Hindu), fakirs (Muslim) – travelled freely – pilgrimage, charity – movements restricted – British East India Company – policies, laws – taxes
- Precise motivations – sannyasis, fakirs – debated – BUT – next 3 decades – attacked British treasuries – tax collectors
- British – called – bandits – executed some – used superior forces – defeat them
- Rebellion – inspired – Bengali writer – Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay – novel – *Anandamath* – 1882

- This novel – contain song – Vande Mataram – inspire Indians – freedom struggle – early 20th cent. – after independence – India's national song

Tribal uprisings

- Tribal comm. – unique threats – British expansion – forests, hills – disrupting – traditional way
- British – describe tribals – primitive – restricted access – forests, forest produce – sometimes – acquire – tribal land – turn it – private prop. – impose taxes – tribals – debt trap – replace traditional councils – British legal sys. – encourage missionaries – civilise, convert tribals – Christianity
- Colonial law – categorize – tribal comm. – criminal tribes – unjust harassment – decades
- Some – above abuse – some tribes – rebellion – colonial power
- 1st such events – **Kol uprising** – 1831-1832 – Chota Nagpur – British introduce – land policies – favour outsiders – over tribal inhabitants
- Kol tribes – Mundas, Oraons – temporary control – significant territory – BUT – defeated by – British forces
- **Santhal rebellion** – 1855-1856 – widespread uprising – Santhal people – present-day – Jharkhand, Bihar, West Bengal – 2 brothers – Sidhu, Kanhu Murmu – rebelled – moneylenders, landlords – taking away – ancestral lands – British support
- Santhals – declared – own govt. – vowed – fight – last drop – blood
- British response – brutal – some initial losses – burned entire villages – killed 1000s of Santhals – incl. – rebel leaders
- BUT – Santhal rebellion – inspired – other tribal comm. – resist colonial rule

Peasant uprisings against economic exploitation

- Without famines – peasants – suffer – unfair British revenue demands – lose land – moneylenders, new landlords
- **Indigo revolt** – 1859-1862 – ex. – exploitation
- European planters – forced peasants – northern part – Bengal – abandon – food crops – instead – grow indigo – indigo dye – great demands – Europe
- Planters, traders – huge profits – except peasants – poorly paid – debt slavery
- Refused – grow indigo – imprisonment, torture, destruction – prop.
- Uprising – directed – planters – retaliated – hire mercenaries – attack peasants
- Cause – support – educated Bengalis, press – British authorities – forced – restrict – worst abuses
- Several more – notable ex. – uprisings – along with – other aspects – British rule – built up – largest uprising – 19th cent.

The Great Rebellion of 1857

- British – called this – Sepoy Mutiny
- Sepoys – Indian soldiers – East India Company – British army – officers – all British
- India's independence – historians – reject term – Sepoy **Mutiny** – propose – few others – we call – Great Rebellion of 1857
- Earlier – several signs – discontent – among sepoys – beginning – Vellore Mutiny – 1806 – British – new uniform regulations – violate – religious practices – Hindu, Muslim
- Ex. – forbidden – religious marks – foreheads – req. – shave beards
- Sepoys – seized Vellore fort – killed – many British officers, troops – BUT – British – crushed revolt – kill, execute – 100s of sepoys

- Also remember – most sepoys – agricultural families – great hardship – British policies – land revenue
- Decades – frustration – 1857 – rumors – northern, central India – rifle cartridges – greased – cow, pig fat – offend – Hindu, Muslim sepoys – religious sensibilities
- Barrackpore – Mangal Pandey – attack – British officers
- His execution – further discontent – among sepoys
- Meerut – some – kill – British officers – marched – Delhi – proclaimed – elderly, politically powerless – Bahadur Shah Jafar – leader
- Military decisions – commanders
- Revolt – spread quick – northern, central India – sepoys capture – key cities – Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi
- Kanpur – rebel forces – Nana Saheb – initial agreement – passage – British civilians – BUT – massacre – 200 men, women, children – reasons – debatable
- British response – sys., brutal – begin – recapture – Delhi – Sept. 1857 – British forces – house-to-house massacre
- Kanpur – mass execution – designed – strike terror – population
- Long campaign – burned villages – destroyed crops – countless deaths – far more than rebels
- Some historians – Great Rebellion – failed – sepoys – heroic leaders – BUT – lack – unified command – consistent strategy
- Uprising failed – BUT – turning point – sowing seed – idea – foreign domination – unacceptable
- Seed grow – early 20th cent. – full-fledged freedom struggle – diff. methods
- 1858 – British crown – direct control – India – initiate period – British Raj
- British policies – shift – territorial expansion to consolidation of control
- Indian army – reorganized – prevent – unified resistance – future

The Legacy of European Colonialism in India

- European (British) conquest – rule of India – not civilisation mission – India's civilisation – much older
- Process – subjugation, exploitation – systematic execution – brutal repression – if necessary
- Small Indian elite grp. – accepted – British rule – inevitable – Indians – suffered – fate – colonized population – abuse, exploitation, violence, uprooting
- Same time – colonial rule – large unintended consequences
- Opened (re-opened) – India to world – world to India
- British (also French) – systematic documentation – every aspect – conquest – geography
- Impressive lists – ethnic grps. – BUT – lists – flawed – unscientific, prevalent notions – race
- Also document – Indian monuments – art, architecture – restore – ruined ones – initiate – discipline – archaeology
- This process – colonial powers – stole 1000s – statues, jewels, paintings, manuscripts – other cultural artifacts – India – sent – European museums, private collections
- This represent – cultural loss – violation – India's heritage – BUT also – promote appreciation – Indian art – European public
- Such theft – much – colonized world – today – efforts, debates – repatriate – some – cultural treasures – origin countries
- British scholars – not – 1st Europeans – master Sanskrit lang. – start publishing – translations – Sanskrit texts – European lang. – French, Germans – others followed
- Motivations – mixed – some scholars – genuine students, admirers – India's culture – others – convinced – studying – Indian lang., texts – easier – demonstrate superiority – Christianity

- Spread – Sanskrit studies, text – Europe – discovery – new continent – words – German philosopher – Georg Hegel
- Indian texts – great impact – European philosophers, writers, poets, artists, statesmen – this influence – extended – USA – 19th cent.
- This reminder – political domination – 1 dir. – cultural influence – opp. dir.
- **Two heroines**
 - **Rani Lakshmibai (Jhansi)** – fought bravely – save kingdom – British annexation – assist – Maratha Tatia (Tantia) Tope – Nana Saheb's military adviser – Rani – managed – escape Jhansi – conquer – Gwalior fort – seize – treasury, arsenal
 - Killed – 18 June 1858 – battlefield
 - British army officer – commanded attack – Jhansi – noted – Rani – remarkable – beauty, cleverness, perseverance, generosity
 - Qualities – combined with rank – most dangerous – all rebel leaders – best, bravest – rebels
 - Tatia Tope – continue fight – early 1859 – BUT – betrayed – handed over – British – hanged him
 - **Begum Hazrat Mahal (Awadh)** – also resist – British resistance – her kingdom – annexed – joined rebels – 1857 – lead defence – Lucknow – British attempt – recapture
 - Rejected British offers – safe passage – if surrendered – take refuge – Nepal
 - Nov. 1858 – Queen Victoria – proclamation – mark end – East India Company rule – promised non-interference – religious matters – greater inclusion – Indians – admin.
 - Begum Hazrat Mahal – counter proclamation – warn Indians – do not trust – such assurances – unvarying custom – English – never forgive fault – great, small